

Nation **BJP**

The Saffron FLYOVER

Backed by the RSS, Gadkari would hope to restore order in the BJP. His challenge, however, will be to find an idea that makes the party—and him—relevant to national politics.

| By Shankkar Aiyar |

October 1999. A few days after the BJP won the polls, Nitin Gadkari went to wish Atal Bihari Vajpayee. The ever mischievous Vajpayee asked Gadkari if there was “a flyover that could connect Bharat with India”. Gadkari said “of course”, and used his experiments to create connectivity for *Adivasi* villages of Melghat for a national blueprint. Result: the much celebrated rural roads programme. A decade later, airdropped by the RSS into the hot seat of the president, Gadkari finds himself facing the challenge of creating connectivity across a party splintered in factions and entrenched in enclaves. He is expected to make the BJP relevant for a modern India. Anyone with a passing acquaintance with the BJP’s intra-party politics would know that it is easier dreamt than done.

The first baby steps, however, were well-scripted. His appointment on December 18 and election by parliamentary party on December 19 was followed by dinner diplomacy with Arun Jaitley, high tea with Sushma Swaraj and *preeti bhojan* with L.K. Advani. The procession in Nagpur and the posters on Asoka Road along with the BJP pantheon of “Atalji and Advaniji” ensured that the symbols of regime change were clear and visible. Real change will obviously take time. It will also require authority that is earned, not bestowed. Yes, he has the backing of the RSS Sarsangchalak, Mohan

Bhagwat. It is also true that for the first time in its history, the RSS has shed all pretence and directly appointed the BJP chief. But the party will have to be run by Gadkari using a mix of cooperation, cooption, collaboration and coercion. In the hierarchy and seniority conscious party, this will be a tough call.

At 52, Gadkari is not only the youngest president but is also younger than 59-year-old Bhagwat. After many years the leadership of the party will be younger than the leadership of the RSS. Advantage Bhagwat though is disadvantage Gadkari. He is leading a party where even the GenNext leaders are senior to the party president. On the face of it the RSS formula enables Jaitley, Swaraj and Gopinath Munde to hold parliamentary positions leaving room for Gadkari to restructure the party.

The first test will obviously be how he casts a team. Early indications reveal a bias for youth, diversity and organisational skills. The names being considered for the core team include Ananth Kumar, Manohar Parrikar, Vasundhara Raje, Piyush Goyal, Vinay Sahasrabudhe, Kirit Somaiya, Syed Shahnawaz Hussain, Ravi Shankar Prasad and Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi. Whatever the composition of the team, the trickiest part would be operational, especially in navigating ex-presidents and next presidents.

IN VAJPAYEE AND ADVANI, BJP HAD BOTH THE BRAND and the bandwagon. Gadkari will need to recreate the brand and mobilise the bandwagon if he is to succeed.



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STRENGTHS

- Backing of RSS
- Commitment to Hindutva
- High Integrity Quotient
- Doesn't stand on formality
- Is a 24x7 politician

Jaitley and Swaraj were not only in the running for the top job, but are also prime ministerial aspirants. Party politics is nothing if not an aggregation of individual aspirations and how much room Gadkari will get to create an impression is debatable. He will be measured and will have to measure up to 24x7 comparisons. His articulation on policy and governance will be compared to that of Jaitley, his oratory with Swaraj. Gadkari, a foodie who loves spicy food, will discover that Delhi serves political masala too spicy for the